Challenge Stigma / Find Peace

FrontlineFolks | Guide #2

Blow Up or Shut Down: Two Sides of the Same Stress Response

A Field Guide for Frontline Folks and Their Families

Fight and freeze are both stress responses. Learn to catch yellow before red.

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Disclaimer

This guide is for general education only.

It is not:

- Therapy
- Medical care
- A crisis service
- Individualized advice

Reading this guide does not create a therapist–client relationship with the author or with Never Forgotten Services, PLLC.

If you are in crisis or thinking about harming yourself or someone else, call 988 in the United States, go to your nearest emergency room, or contact your local emergency services.

If you want mental health treatment, please contact a licensed provider in your state or call the number on the back of your insurance card.

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1. Two Stress Modes, One Nervous System

Some days your stress response comes out as intensity, volume, and anger. Other days it comes out as numbness, silence, and emotional disappearance. Both are protective states, not moral failures.

Blow up mode

- voice gets sharp or loud
- body moves fast and hard
- you push to control the environment

Shut down mode

- you go flat, quiet, and hard to reach
- you avoid eye contact and conversation
- you disconnect to avoid making it worse

2. Your Yellow Zone Is the Intervention Window

Red is expensive. Yellow is workable. If you can detect yellow, you can prevent both blowups and shutdowns.

GREEN - Connected and flexible
You can listen, think, and respond.

YELLOW - Loaded and narrowing
Body tension rises, thinking gets rigid, tone shifts.

RED - Unsafe for useful conversation
You are likely to damage trust if you continue.

3. Practical Interrupts for Blow Up and Shut Down

1. **Name yellow:** say, 'I am getting loaded,' before your body chooses for you.
2. **Use a movement reset:** walk, breathe, cold water, or wall push for 60-120 seconds.
3. **Set return time:** never pause without saying when you will re-engage.

4. **Repair quickly:** apology plus behavior change restores safety faster than silence.

4. Partner Scripts That Reduce Damage

- Use short phrases: 'You are yellow. Want 20 minutes?'
- Avoid character attacks during activation.
- Do not chase someone in shutdown with rapid-fire questions.
- After red, schedule a repair conversation with one clear objective.

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5. When This Pattern Needs Clinical Support

- Frequent verbal aggression, intimidation, or emotional disappearance.
- Family members are modifying life to avoid your reactions.
- Shame cycles are increasing substance use or hopelessness.
- Repair attempts are not changing outcomes over several weeks.

6. 7-Day Red/Yellow/Green Drill

At end of each day, mark your highest zone, what moved you there, and whether you used a yellow intervention in time.

> **Daily target:**
> One yellow call-out before red.
> One agreed pause-and-return.
> One repair if rupture occurred.

Worksheet 1: Worksheet: Blow Up or Shut Down - Pattern Tracker

Map whether your stress response went explosive, avoidant, or both, and what worked to interrupt it.

When did you move toward blow up this week?

List the setting, trigger, and first warning cue.

When did you move toward shut down this week?

List where you disconnected, went silent, or emotionally disappeared.

What yellow intervention will you use next time?

Choose one action and one phrase to deploy before red.

1. State transition:

What shifted you from green to yellow?

2. First body cue:

Heat, tight jaw, shallow breath, numbness, tunnel hearing, etc.

3. Reset action used:

What interrupted escalation in under two minutes?

4. Repair needed:

If damage occurred, what exact repair will you do?

> Success is not never going yellow. Success is fewer reds and faster repairs.

Worksheet 2: Worksheet: Blow Up or Shut Down - Shared Safety Plan

Use this with partner or family to define what yellow and red look like and what each person will do.

Observable yellow signs

List behaviors each person can reliably identify.

Red protocol

What happens immediately when either person calls red?

Repair protocol

How and when will you complete repair after red?

1. Signal phrase:

Short phrase both people agree to honor.

2. Return-time commitment:

Exact time to reconnect after pause.

3. First repair sentence:

Write the first line you will use in repair conversation.

> A shared protocol turns chaos into a plan.

Closing

Blow up and shut down are not opposite personalities. They are different exits from the same overloaded nervous system.

The skill is not perfection. The skill is naming yellow, pausing early, and repairing fast.

About the Author

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Michael is a U.S. Army combat veteran and licensed clinical social worker who specializes in working with military, veterans, and first responders—our frontline folks. After leaving the military, he spent years fighting his own demons and trying to figure out why he could hold it together on the job but feel completely wrecked at home. The turning point was realizing he wasn't the only one living that split life—and that nobody should have to feel that alone, confused, or broken by what the job asks of them.

Since then, his work has focused on trauma, the impact of high-stress jobs on home life, and helping families make sense of what the job brings home. He uses plain language, zero shame, and a "you're not crazy, this actually makes sense" approach to help frontline folks and their families understand what's happening in their nervous systems and learn how to move through the chaos together.